

Iran's Respect for Religions Depicts Its Rich Culture

Ms. Yaroslava Romanova, the Cultural Attaché of the Italian Embassy in Iran

In the course of unveiling the Italian translation of the book “Iran, the Cradle of Religious” Ms. Yaroslava Romanova, the Cultural Attaché of the Italian Embassy in Iran said that Iran's respect for all religions depicts its rich culture.

The unveiling ceremony of the Italian translation of the book “Iran, the Cradle of Religious Coexistence” was held on Friday, May 20, 2022, at the Hall of Nations of the thirty-third Tehran International Book Fair.

The ceremony was attended by Dr. Ali Akbar Ziaei, Head of the Center for the Interreligious and Intercultural Dialogue, Ms. Yaroslava Romanova, the Cultural Attaché of the Italian Embassy in Iran, Ms. Zahra Rashidbeigi, author of the book, Mohammad Rasoul Almasieh, Director of the Center for Organizing Translation and Publication, and some other directors of the Islamic Culture and Relations Organization.

Dr. Ziaei, the first speaker of this meeting said: The publication of the book “Iran, Iran, the Cradle of Religious Coexistence” is one of the honors of the Islamic Culture and Relations Organization. This organization has translated and published many research works on different religions.

He then introduced the author of this book and added: The works written by Ms. Rashidbeigi have are basically of research essence and she had face-to-face meetings with the leaders of different religions to write this book, and, thus, her works are based on the experiences they have gained over the years.

Dr. Ziaei added: “Judaism in Iran” and “Christianity in Iran” are the other works of this researcher in the area of religion and the book “Iran, Iran, the Cradle of Religious Coexistence” is her latest work in this field. He also referred to the publication of this book in English and Russian languages and added that it will also be translated into Georgian soon.

Ziaei stated that the main subject of this book is a report on how different religions function freely in Iran, elaborates on the rights that have been provided to the followers of these religions in Iran, and how they engage in their religious activities and are free to publish and present their works.

He concluded his speech by elaborating the reason behind the translation of this book into Italian and added the publication of books published by our organization in any language depends upon the demand for them in different countries and the translation and publication of this book have been done at the request of a publisher in Italy.

Ms. Rashidbeigi was then ext speaker of the program who thanked the Center for Interreligious and Intercultural Dialogue for supporting her research, the Center for Organizing the Publication and Translation of Islamic Teachings and Humanities, the Office of Cultural Counselor of Iran in Italy for having the book translated by Ms. Giorgia Dorigon, and its digital publication by IL CERCHIO Publications for its digital publication.

She stated that the purpose of publishing this book, which is the result of several years of research, is to get to know the followers of different religions in Iran more and to show the coexistence among the followers of religions in Iran. In fact, this book is an introduction to finding ways to interact, collaborate, and understand challenges and turn them into opportunities. We in Iran have diverse religious minorities that are as old as Iranian history. Thus, before publishing the book, we took this work to the religious leaders and asked them to let us know their views.

Ms. Yaroslava Romanova, the Cultural Attaché of the Italian Embassy in Iran was the other speaker in this program and emphasized that promoting religious freedom is one of our priorities in Italy. Although Catholicism is the most common religion in Italy due to the existence of the Vatican Church, we respect all religions. Thus, with respect to the diversity of religions, we are very similar to Iran and many Muslims, Jews and people of ancient religions live in Italy. She then added that this book can introduce Iran to the Italians. The Italians are not aware of the diversity of religions in Iran and think that only Shiites live in this country. That's why this book is important to us. She concluded by thanking the Center for Interreligious and Intercultural Dialogue of the Islamic Culture and Relations Organization for the publication of this book.

Dr. Almasiyeh was the next speaker and said: With regard to translation and publication of books we are demand-driven and act as per the requests we receive from local applicants. And as mentioned by my colleagues this book was translated at the request of an Italian scholar and the translator and publisher were native Italians.

The last speaker of the program was Mohammad Reza Ghezelsofla, Iran's Cultural Counselor in Uganda who said that in the last two years, two books have been translated in Uganda and have been very well received. The book "Iran, the Cradle of Religious Coexistence", which was in English, was republished and distributed in collaboration with Macaulay University in Africa. Fortunately, this book portrayed a good and clear picture of the followers of different religions in Iran in the Ugandan Interfaith Council and among Christian personalities, many of whom did not know much about the religious minorities of Iran and the rights they enjoy.